The inspiration for this little child's money box is an example created some 200 years ago. The spa town of Royal Tunbridge Wells first attracted wealthy tourists towards the end of the 17th century who came to 'take the waters', hoping to cure the gout and many other ailments. As today, before returning home there was a desire to purchase a few gifts and reminders of their stay and in Royal Tunbridge Wells, this often meant a turned wooden souvenir.

As the popularity of this Kentish town grew so did the business of producing knick-knacks on the lathe to satisfy demand, the early items were quite simple pieces of woodenware, often lidded boxes decorated with coloured lines. Slowly the products became more sophisticated in decoration and function leading to a wider variety of items including many sewing accoutrements such as tape measures, pincushions and complete sewing sets. Inkwell stands and small snuffboxes were also popular.

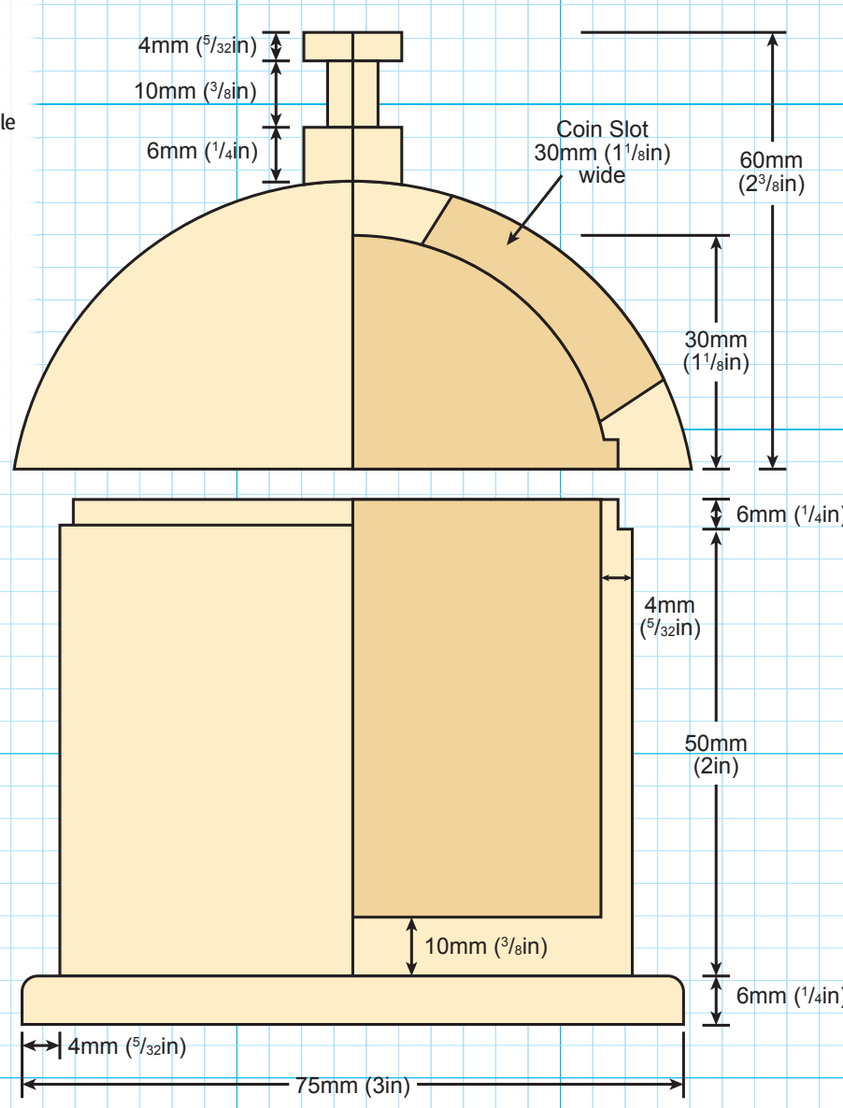
By the beginning of the 19th century engraved pictorial illustrations were pasted on such things as box lids and the use of more sophisticated hand painted all-over decoration was more common. However, quite quickly during the early 19th century this simplistic style was replaced by the most intricate parquetry, marquetry and micro mosaic for decoration.

This brings us to this project; I think that it is charming in its simplicity, a true example of English folk art and a project that will allow some individual imagination in its making and decoration. Many of the original turnings were of birch (*Betula pendula*); I just happened to a have a suitable well seasoned block of lime (*Tilia vulgaris*), a white wood that allows for a wide choice of decoration.

Antique Tunbridge Ware child's money box

PLANS & EQUIPMENT

EQUIPMENT USED
10mm round skew
10mm standard ground spindle gouge
10mm spindle gouge with fingernail profile
10mm bowl gouge with fingernail profile
10mm box scraper
6mm skew
4mm parting tool
3mm round nose scraper
4mm drill bit – plus drill
Craft knife
Revolving centre
Four-prong drive
Chuck
Toy-safe paints, pens or finishes



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